around CAA is built on the 'persecution of religious minorities in Islamic countries', nowhere in the Act is this mentioned. The newly notified rules also do not demand from the applicant proof that they were being persecuted.

THE BENGAL GAME

Irrespective of the legal criticism, the citizenship matrix is likely to polarise Hindu votes in favour of the BJP, especially in West Bengal. The implementation of CAA fulfils a long-term demand of the Matua community here and, in the Lok Sabha polls, could help the saffron party in at least five seats where they have substantial numbers. The Matuas are Hindu Namasudras, or Dalits, who migrated to India in large numbers during Partition and, later, during the 1971 Bangladesh Liberation War. While most of them already have voting rights and hence the issue of citizenship is only of symbolic value, the community finds the BJP's backing of Hindu immigrants appealing, perhaps because they have been victims of Islamic radicalism in the past. Some of them also see the Trinamool Congress's opposition to CAA in West Bengal as Muslim appeasement.



LET IT BLOOM
Sindhi refugees from Pakistan thank the Centre in Bhopal, Mar. 12

ANI

The Matua electorate, according to some estimates, is around 17.5 million, accounting for 15 per cent of the state's population. The BJP's promise of citizenship to the community helped the party take 18 of the 42 LS seats in West Bengal in 2019, which included leads in 33 of the 68 SC-reserved assembly segments. Of these 33 seats, 26 are Matua-dominated. However, the saffron party's inability to come through on the CAA affected the results in the 2021 assembly election. In the 26 Matua-dominated seats, the BJP won only 14 while the TMC bagged 12. The saffron party hopes to make amends in the coming election.

As expected, the TMC has come out strongly against the CAA. Accusing the BJP of trying to create unrest in the state, CM Mamata Banerjee warned of the downside of applying for citizenship under the CAA—applicants would become illegal immigrants and potentially lose existing rights and privileges. She also raised the issue of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in Assam, which had left out 1.9 million people. Claiming that 1.3 million of them are Hindus, the TMC chief said the moment they apply for citizenship via CAA, they will be declared illegal infiltrators and sent to detention camps.

From a legal perspective, the CAA and NRC are not connected. CAA is an inclusionary process, and doesn't take away citizenship from anyone. The NRC aims to create a record of all citizens of the country (and identify illegals). The idea of a countrywide NRC first emerged in 2003 under the BJP-led NDA government of Atal Bihari Vajpayee. On the recommendation of a group of ministers (GoM) reviewing national security after the 1999 Kargil War, the Citizenship Act, 1955, was amended and it was decided that every citizen, particularly in the border areas, would be provided with an identity card. The next year, when the Congress-led UPA government came to power, Section 14A, compulsory registration for every citizen of India—creating a National Register of Citizens—was inserted in the Citizenship Act. The rules for implementation of the same have never been framed, though.

It's the BJP's penchant for height-